

with one stone ("Sleeping Over Intelligence", November 19). One, it effectively deflects the gaze of the media and the public from the main issues. Two, such exercises create a number of well-cushioned jobs for a number of retired officials. **KARAN KHARB, Noida**

Paradise Lost

The article on the mess in Kerala, shows the need of the hour ("God's Disowned Country", November 19). The state's civic authorities must take lessons from their counterparts in Ladakh where they have been able to preserve the natural beauty of the region. What is the point in being 100 per cent literate but uneducated?

RAMESH NAMBIAR, Delhi

Time to Clean Up

The need for proper sanitation facilities including toilets has been taken for a laugh since long ("Toilet Training", November 19). It is time people took notice of the 700 million countrymen who have to defecate in the open.

H.R. BAPU SATYANARAYANA, Anand

Well Gotten, Ill Spent

The wealth that Mukesh Ambani has been able to create is like that pearl in the deep sea which is not being harvested ("Money Machine", November 12). Even if he puts 1 per cent of his money into social causes like spreading education in rural areas, millions will benefit. Alas, while there is enough money to be spent on gifts, there

is none for noble causes. **Y.N.I. ANAND, Mysore**

Flying Ain't Easy

The lure of money and glamour seems to have inspired many to become commercial pilots ("Look Who is Flying You", November 12). What most people do not know is that an airline pilot's job is one of the most arduous jobs on earth. To sit on the ground and look upward with starry eyes is one thing and to look down

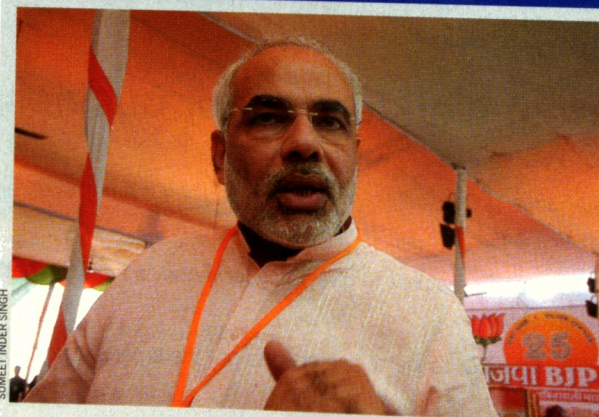
upon terra firma enclosed in a metal tube hurtling across the sky at the speed of sound and at a height of 40,000 ft is another.

MANOJ K. MANILAL, on e-mail

Correction

The name of one of the authors of *A Certain Ambiguity: A Mathematical Novel* was wrongly given as Gautam Suri ("A Parallel Universe", November 19). The correct name is Gaurav Suri. The error is regretted.

STING IN THE TALE



Narendra Modi is bound to face difficulties in winning over the minorities for he is in the land of the Mahatma ("Sins of Silence", November 12). In a secular country like ours, people like Modi cannot be successful leaders.

K. PRADEEP, Chennai

Silence is better than words that mean nothing. Repetition of an allegation does not establish its validity. Paid sting operations fetch zero encomiums. The media needs to be impartial in its dealings.

A.S. RAJ, on e-mail

Hindus and Muslims of this country must live together as members of a large family. Whenever there is a family feud, there are bound to be malicious characters who find pleasure in pitting one member against the other. Sting operators are one of those.

S.N. SHARMA, Gurgaon

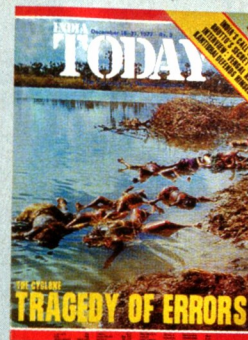
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Years Ago in India Today

DECEMBER 16-30, 1977



A Maharashtrian Messiah?

Bal Thackeray, 52-year-old founder-leader of one of country's largest militant organisations—the Shiv Sena—is also one of the country's most controversial personalities. Excerpts from an interview:

On Shiv Sena's ideology: Live and let live is my philosophy. I only want to safeguard the rights of my people.



On Bombay **Thackeray** being a cosmopolitan city: Though Bombay is a cosmopolitan city, it does not mean our own people should be deprived of their rights here.

On his anti-south Indian and Muslim attitude: As a cartoonist, I see a satirical streak in most situations and sometimes make remarks in a humorous vein.

On whether Indira Gandhi can stage a comeback: It depends on the people to accept her or reject her. She has done a lot of good for the country.

—Shobha Kilachand

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